escaped the imprint.' Once in Army HQ, Palit had changed his opinion, for Thorat's defensive line was not based on a whim but on pure military logic of fighting a war on grounds of your own choosing and playing to one's strengths rather than weaknesses.

Right from the very beginning, Palit was not particularly impressed with Tawang as a defensive location. He says: 'After my reconnaissance of the Bum-la region, I was more than ever convinced that Towang (sic) was not suitable as a defensive locality. Then, for the first time, it occurred to me that the Se-la ridge was a possible alternative. I resolved to make a more detailed survey of the terrain on either side of Se-la Top, where the map indicated a number of tracks, many flat stretches for dropping zones and two small freshwater lakes.' However, Palit's own attempt at studying the ground around Se-la and Nuranang had proved futile owing to a snowstorm and ill health. 'Afterwards I had sent Major Raja Fulay, my DAA and QMG (logistics officer) to reconnoitre Se-la's surroundings for both tactical and logistical assessments of its defensive potential. I instructed him to return via the circuitous northern track from Tawang that bypasses Se-la, skirts the high Mago region and descends to Dirang valley via Tse-la (pronounced Che-la), Poshing-la and Thembang. This was a possible route for outflanking Se-la and I needed to have a detailed report on it.'

It was a different matter that Niranjan Prasad had also arrived at much the same conclusion. Prasad had never commanded troops at a junior level; in fact, he had been seconded to the RIAF during World War II as a junior officer and had flown the Lysander with No. 1 Squadron before moving on to command No. 7 Squadron. He had moved back to the army and commanded 50 Para Brigade in the Jammu and Kashmir Ops in 1948. There too, his lack of experience in commanding troops at the grass-roots level had shown up, and he was fortunate to have been given a leg-up to the next rank. He obviously had a pleasing personality and was generally well liked, but his tendency of developing a fatalistic and supine attitude on the eve of a battle was liable to create problems.

On 22 October while the drama was being enacted between Prasad and Sen in Tawang, Palit was moving rapidly in Delhi. He first went to Kaul's residence but was unable to get his attention owing to the circle of Thapar, Menon, Mullik and Sarin around him. He then accosted Thapar as he came out of Kaul's residence and told the chief that in his opinion, trying to defend Tawang would lead to another Nam Ka Chu and that the army must